

Sports in Progress



By Chris Cramer

It's that time of year again—open season on major league baseball managers. Two, both in the National League, have become victims in the span of five days. First to feel the sting of the axe was Gene Mauch of the Philadelphia Phillies. Yesterday Grady Hatton of the Houston Astros went on the chopping block.

Mauch had been skipper of the Phillies since 1960 when he assumed command of the ball club after two games had been played. The Phillies launched the 1960 season with Eddie Sawyer at the helm, but Sawyer suddenly resigned after the opening game. Coach Andy Cohen served as acting manager for one game before Mauch took over. The Phils finished eighth that season with a 58-94 record. Things got worse the following year when the Phils were again mired in eighth place and only managed 47 victories.

Mauch's best season was 1964 when Philadelphia won 92 games and finished in a tie for second place. He managed to bring them home in fourth place twice in 1963 and '66. The Phils replaced Mauch last week with Bob Skinner.

Old Axiom Still Scream

There's an old axiom in baseball, as in most sports for that matter. It's the "be good or be gone" rule and so Mauch and Hatton have gotten the gate. Chances are there will be others before the season is over. Chances are also good that both will eventually wind up with another major league club under their direction.

It wasn't too many years ago that many baseball observers referred to Mauch as one of the best baseball minds in the managerial corps although he never had a first place club, even during three seasons of managing in the minor leagues.

Grady Edgebert Hatton, Jr., 45-year-old native of Beaumont, Texas, was in his third campaign as Houston manager. In two previous seasons the Astros finished eighth in 1966 and ninth last year. In his first year, the Astros were the surprise of the league for the first half of the year but injuries crippled them and they sagged to eighth place. Then they slipped to ninth and this season they occupy the cellar.

Hatton was replaced by batting coach Harry (The Hat) Walker, a prominent member of the former major league managers club. He piloted the Pittsburgh Pirates until the middle of last season when he too was fired. He was promptly signed by Houston as a batting coach. However, Walker had an earlier stint as a manager with the Cardinals in 1955.

Houston general manager Spec Richardson yesterday made what has become almost a stock comment on the firing of Hatton.

"I want to make it clear," he said, "that we are not blaming Grady for the disappointing record of our club. But we felt a change was necessary and would be best for all concerned."

Then, as is so often the case with the deposed manager, Richardson said that Hatton had been asked to remain with the Houston organization and had accepted a position as special assignment man under the general manager.

And so the game of musical chairs among baseball managers continues on its merry way. Richardson's statement concerning Hatton could almost be fitted to that of any general manager the day a club decides to make a change in field bosses.

The strategy is as familiar as the vote of confidence statements of owners and general managers which, all too often, are a warning that another "nice guy" is about to be canned.

But what it all adds up to, really, is that no ball club is going to win without superior talent. Without such talent, there is little that any manager can accomplish.